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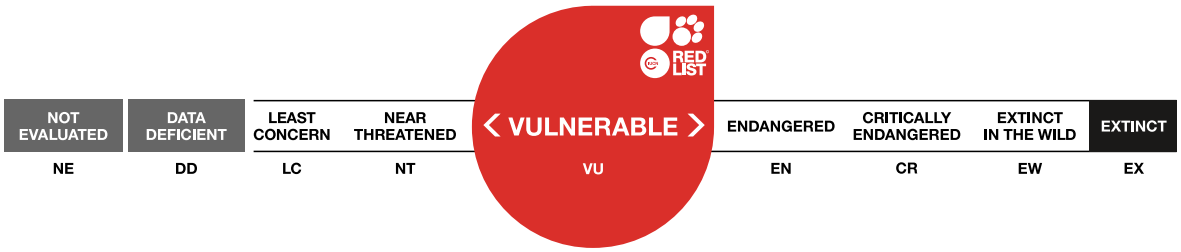
# *Cebus capucinus,* Colombian White-throated Capuchin

## Amendment version

**Assessment by: de la Torre, S., Moscoso, P., Méndez-Carvajal, P.G., Rosales-Meda, M., Palacios, E., Link, A., Lynch Alfaro, J.W. & Mittermeier, R.A.**

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# Taxonomy

| Kingdom | Phylum | Class | Order | Family |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Animalia | Chordata | Mammalia | Primates | Cebidae |

**Scientific Name:** *Cebus capucinus* (Linnaeus, 1758)

**Synonym(s):**

- *Simia capucina* Linnaeus, 1758

**Infra-specific Taxa Assessed:**

- Cebus capucinus ssp. capucinus
- Cebus capucinus ssp. curtus

**Common Name(s):**

- English: Colombian White-throated Capuchin, White-faced Capuchin, White-headed Capuchin, White-throated Capuchin
- French: Sapajou capucin
- Spanish; Castilian: Capuchino de Cara Blanca de Colombia
- German: Weißschulter-Kapuzineraffe

**Taxonomic Notes:**

Silva Jr (2001, 2002) argued that the tufted capuchins and the untufted capuchins (*sensu* Hershkovitz 1949, 1955) are so distinct in their morphology that they should be considered separate genera. *Cebus* Erxleben, 1777 is referable to the untufted group, and *Sapajus* Kerr, 1792 is the name available for the tufted capuchins.

Defler (2004) noted that three subspecies had been recorded for Colombia: *C. c. capucinus* (Linnaeus, 1758), *C. c. nigripectus* Elliot, 1909; and *C. c. curtus* Bangs, 1905, of the Pacific Island of Gorgona. They are not recognized as valid by Hershkovitz (1949), Hernández-Camacho and Cooper (1976), nor by Groves (2001, 2005).

The assessment of *C. capucinus* previously included four subspecies but *capucinus* is now treated as being limited to Colombia with just two subspecies – *C. c. capucinus* and the Gorgona Island *C. c. curtus.* Subspecies *imitator is* now considered a good species (from Panama) and subspecies *limitaneus is* now a junior synonym of *C. imitator*. These changes are based on Molecular genetic studies by Ruiz-García *et al*. (2012) and Boubli *et al*. (2012) which validated *C. imitator* as the Central American form, restricting *C. c. capucinus* to Colombia, and eliminating *limitaneus* as a junior synonym of *imitator*.

# Assessment Information

**Red List Category & Criteria:** Vulnerable A4cd ver 3.1

**Year Published:** 2021

**Date Assessed:** March 2, 2020

**Justification:**

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*Cebus capucinus* is considered Vulnerable, as a population reduction of 30% or more is suspected over the course of three generations. This is based on Global Forest Watch data for regions of eastern Panama, the Pacific coast of Colombia and northwestern Ecuador in which this species is known or believed to occur. The data suggest that, should forest loss continue at the same rate that has impacted the previous generation, up to 18% of this species' suitable habitat is likely to be lost by the year 2074. Combined with continued evidence of hunting for the pet trade and in retaliation for crop-raiding, these threats put *Cebus capucinus* above the threshold for Vulnerable status.

### Previously Published Red List Assessments

2020 – Vulnerable (VU)
https://dx.doi.org/10.2305/IUCN.UK.2020-3.RLTS.T81257277A17938441.en

## Geographic Range

### Range Description:

*Cebus capucinus* ranges from east of the Panama Canal watershed, including Chagres National Park (Panama Province), Portobelo National Park (Colon Province), Comarca San Blas Indigenous Reserve, Panama (Méndez 1970), Bayano, Maje Mountain Chain, Chucantí Natural Reserve and Darien National Park (Méndez-Carvajal 2014) through the Chocó-Darién into Colombia to NW Ecuador (south to the Esmeraldas and Guayllabamba Rivers) (Hernández-Camacho and Cooper 1976; Rodríguez-Luna *et al.* 1996; Reid 1997; Marineros and Gallegos 1998, Mittermeier *et al*. 2013).

Global Forest Watch data for regions of eastern Panama, the Pacific coast of Colombia and northwestern Ecuador in which this species is known or believed to occur, suggest that, should forest loss continue at the same rate that has impacted the previous generation (2009-2018), up to 18% of this species' suitable habitat is likely to be lost by the year 2074 (Global Forest Watch 2020).
Two subspecies are recognized:

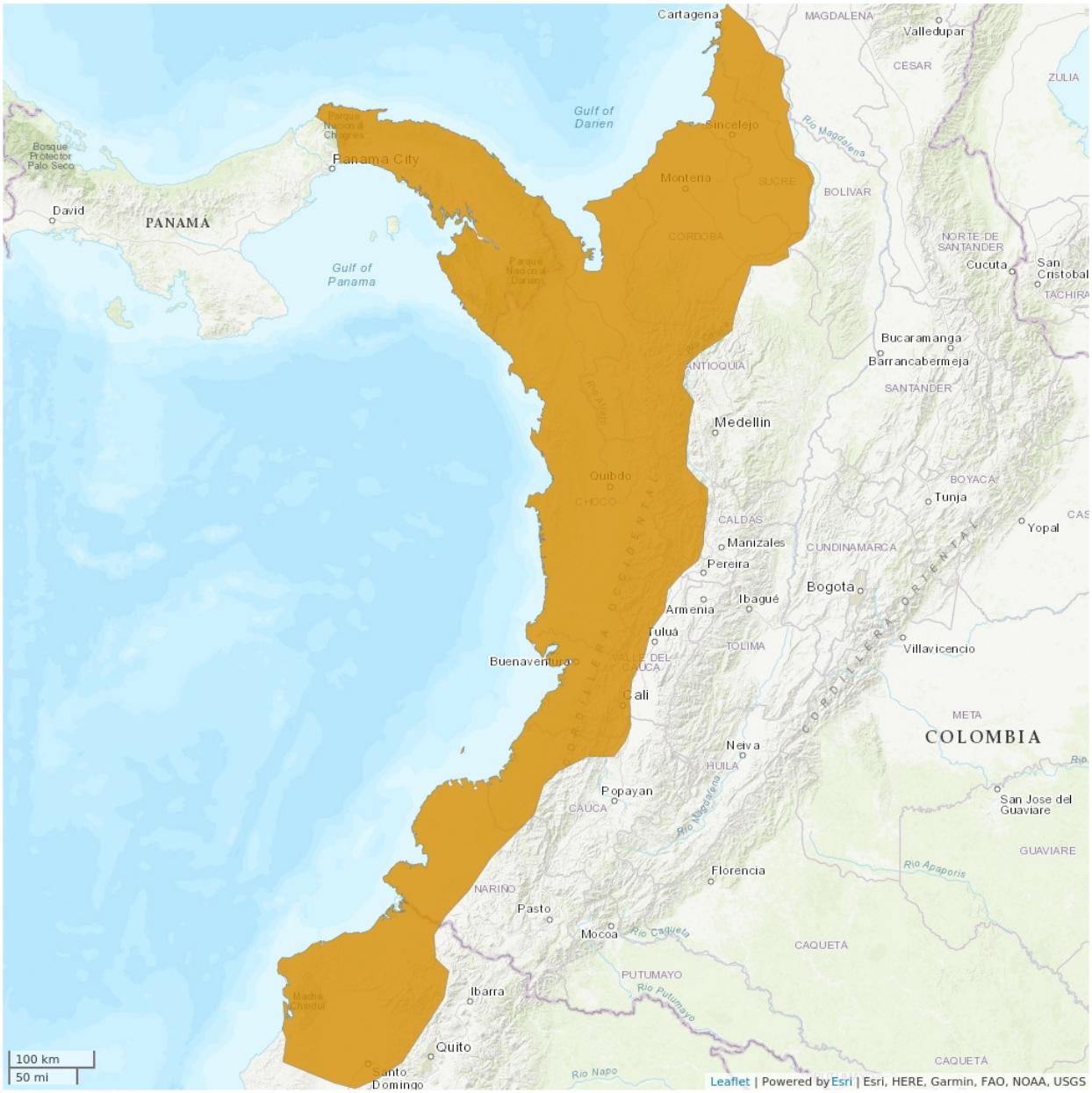
*Cebus capucinus capucinus*
In Colombia, the white-throated capuchin occurs south from the Panamanian border along the Pacific Coast, west of the Andes (up to 1,800–2,000 m asl) into northwestern Ecuador. It is restricted to the west bank of the upper Río Cauca (between the Cordillera Occidental and Cordillera Central) and extends north across the Río Sinu into Cordoba, Sucre and Atlantico to the town of Barranquilla on the northern coast of Colombia. It also occurs in NW Ecuador (Hernández-Camacho and Cooper 1976; Defler 2004, Tirira 2007). In Central America, *C. c. capucinus* extends west as far the Panama Canal (Baldwin and Baldwin 1977; Hall 1981).

*Cebus capucinus curtus*
Gorgona Island, Colombia, possibly introduced in the 16th or 17th centuries.

### Country Occurrence:

**Native, Extant (resident):** Colombia (Colombia (mainland)); Ecuador (Ecuador (mainland)); Panama

# Distribution Map




Legend

EXTANT (RESIDENT)

Compiled by:

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The boundaries and names shown and the designations used on this map do not imply any official endorsement, acceptance or opinion by IUCN.

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## Population

No information on population densities are available for this species. A population reduction of 30% or more is inferred over the course of three generations due to habitat degradation and the pet trade.

**Current Population Trend:** Decreasing

## Habitat and Ecology (see Appendix for additional information)

In Panama, the species occurs in dry deciduous forests on the Pacific coast (rainfall less than 1,75 mm), in mangroves and second growth (Freese and Oppenheimer 1981, Reid 1997). In Colombia, *C. capucinus* occurs in primary and advanced secondary forest remnants, degraded forests and forests with large concentrations of palms, especially *Scheelea magdalenica* at altitudes of up to 2,000 m asl (Defler 2004). In Ecuador, it occurs in humid tropical and subtropical forests from sea level to 1,800 m asl (Tirira 2007).

Capuchins are frugivores-insectivores, including a wide variety of fruits, seeds, arthropods, frogs, nestlings and even small mammals in their diet, supplemented by stems, flowers and leaves. They are extractive, manipulative foragers. In a cloud forest in Ecuador (Los Cedros Protected Forest) the species has been reported to be a generalist, inhabiting all types of forest, including grassland with *Cecropia* trees (Gavilanes-Endara 2007, Estévez-Noboa 2009). It uses mainly the canopy and mid-story level, in trees between 15 and 24 m height (Gavilanes-Endara 2007). Males disperse. Both sexes take up linear hierarchies, the top ranking male being dominant to the top ranking female. Multi-male groups range in size from 5-30 individuals. In Chiriqui, Panama, Baldwin and Baldwin (1977) found *C. capucinus* occupying small forest patches of 0.2 to 40 ha in small groups of 2-5 individuals, whereas groups in larger forests reached sizes of 20 or more individuals. The home range size for the species averages around 50 to 80 ha (Defler 2004).

**Systems:** Terrestrial

## Use and Trade

The species is hunted as a crop pest and for the pet market.

## Threats (see Appendix for additional information)

Although habitat loss is certainly a major threat, the species is also hunted in several areas as a crop pest and for the pet market. In Panama, local people hunt them to prevent crop raiding, eliminating several groups near to protected areas (Méndez-Carvajal pers. obs.). They are sometimes kept as pets. *Cebus capucinus curtus* occurs only on Gorgona Island, which is a protected area (Parque Nacional Gorgona). However, as this is the only location in which this subspecies is found (Gorgona Island has an area of 15 km²), it remains very susceptible to many natural or anthropogenic threats.

## Conservation Actions (see Appendix for additional information)

This species is listed on CITES Appendix II. It is present in the following protected areas:

*Cebus capucinus capucinus*

• PanamaPortobelo National Park (34,848 ha) (Matamoros and Seal 2001)

• Chagres National Park (129,000 ha) (Matamoros and Seal 2001)
• Chucanti Nature Reserve (Méndez-Carvajal 2012)
• Darién National Park (555,000 ha) (Matamoros and Seal 2001)
• EcuadorCotacachi-Cayapas Ecological Reserve (Tirira 2007)
• Cayapas Mataje Ecological Reserve (Tirira 2007)
• Los Cedros Protected Forest (Tirira 2007)
• Río Canandé Reserve (Moscoso pers. obs)
• El Pambilar Wildlife Refuge (Tacuri *et al.* 2013)

*Cebus capucinus curtus*

• ColombiaIsla Gorgona National Natural Park (1,568 ha)

## Credits

| | |
|---|---|
| **Assessor(s):** | de la Torre, S., Moscoso, P., Méndez-Carvajal, P.G., Rosales-Meda, M., Palacios, E., Link, A., Lynch Alfaro, J.W. & Mittermeier, R.A. |
| **Reviewer(s):** | Cotton, A., Molur, S., Schwitzer, C. & Reuter, K.E. |
| **Facilitator(s) and Compiler(s):** | Angelico, M. & Konstant, W.R. |
| **Authority/Authorities:** | IUCN SSC Primate Specialist Group |

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# Appendix

## Habitats
(http://www.iucnredlist.org/technical-documents/classification-schemes)

| Habitat | Season | Suitability | Major Importance? |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1. Forest -> 1.5. Forest - Subtropical/Tropical Dry | - | Suitable | Yes |
| 1. Forest -> 1.6. Forest - Subtropical/Tropical Moist Lowland | - | Suitable | Yes |
| 1. Forest -> 1.8. Forest - Subtropical/Tropical Swamp | - | Suitable | Yes |
| 1. Forest -> 1.9. Forest - Subtropical/Tropical Moist Montane | - | Suitable | Yes |
| 2. Savanna -> 2.2. Savanna - Moist | - | Suitable | - |

## Use and Trade
(http://www.iucnredlist.org/technical-documents/classification-schemes)

| End Use | Local | National | International |
|---|---|---|---|
| Food - human | Yes | No | No |
| Pets/display animals, horticulture | Yes | No | No |

## Threats
(http://www.iucnredlist.org/technical-documents/classification-schemes)

| Threat | Timing | Scope | Severity | Impact Score |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1. Residential & commercial development -> 1.1. Housing & urban areas | Ongoing | - | - | Low impact: 3 |
| | Stresses: | 1. Ecosystem stresses -> 1.1. Ecosystem conversion<br>1. Ecosystem stresses -> 1.2. Ecosystem degradation | | |
| 5. Biological resource use -> 5.1. Hunting & trapping terrestrial animals -> 5.1.1. Intentional use (species is the target) | Ongoing | - | - | Low impact: 3 |
| | Stresses: | 2. Species Stresses -> 2.1. Species mortality | | |
| 5. Biological resource use -> 5.3. Logging & wood harvesting -> 5.3.5. Motivation Unknown/Unrecorded | Ongoing | - | - | Low impact: 3 |
| | Stresses: | 1. Ecosystem stresses -> 1.2. Ecosystem degradation | | |

## Conservation Actions in Place
(http://www.iucnredlist.org/technical-documents/classification-schemes)

| Conservation Action in Place |
| --- |
| In-place land/water protection |
| Conservation sites identified: Yes, over entire range |
| In-place education |
| Included in international legislation: Yes |
| Subject to any international management / trade controls: Yes |

## Conservation Actions Needed

**(http://www.iucnredlist.org/technical-documents/classification-schemes)**

| Conservation Action Needed |
| --- |
| 2. Land/water management -> 2.1. Site/area management |

## Research Needed

**(http://www.iucnredlist.org/technical-documents/classification-schemes)**

| Research Needed |
| --- |
| 1. Research -> 1.2. Population size, distribution & trends |
| 1. Research -> 1.3. Life history & ecology |
| 1. Research -> 1.5. Threats |
| 3. Monitoring -> 3.1. Population trends |

## Additional Data Fields

| Distribution |
| --- |
| Continuing decline in area of occupancy (AOO): Yes |
| Continuing decline in extent of occurrence (EOO): Yes |
| Upper elevation limit (m): 1,800 |
| **Population** |
| Population severely fragmented: No |
| **Habitats and Ecology** |
| Continuing decline in area, extent and/or quality of habitat: Yes |
| Generation Length (years): 18 |

# Amendment

**Amendment reason:** The list of Assessor names has been corrected in this assessment.

# The IUCN Red List Partnership

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